INTERNATIONAL CYBERSECURITY AND DIGITAL FORENSICS ACADEMY (ICDFA)

Governance, Compliance, and Risk (GCR)

Phase 2, Course 5: GRC205 - Incident Management and Business Continuity

Business Continuity and Disaster Recovery Assignment:

on "Crisis Communication and Stakeholder Management"

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ABSTRACT

In this assignment exercise, I formulated a comprehensive Crisis Communication and Stakeholder Management response for a simulated ransomware attack occurring during a high-stakes payroll week. I began by establishing a rigorous Four-Quadrant Source of Truth ledger at 08:30 to separate confirmed facts from assumptions, manage unverified leaks, and maintain strict disclosure hygiene. Next, I mapped five core stakeholder cohorts, direct workforce, executive leadership, banking and payroll partners, regulators and legal counsel, and key customers, identifying their distinct informational needs and establishing resilient channel architectures independent of compromised corporate networks.

I then structured the initial 4-hour operational window (08:30 to 12:30) to execute a coordinated sequence of communications, including an immediate incident command alignment, an employee holding statement addressing a circulating unverified screenshot, a strategic executive briefing, and customer updates. To uphold institutional credibility under extreme uncertainty, I enforced strict non-disclosure parameters regarding unverified root causes, attacker identities, and premature payroll guarantees, while defining clear escalation thresholds and multi-cadence update schedules. Finally, I evaluated channel resilience protocols, established failure rules for out-of-band communication channels, and reflected on the core operational tension between rapid stakeholder reassurance and strict factual accuracy.

Overall, this assignment deepened my practical knowledge of orchestrating structured crisis communications, protecting organizational trust during active cybersecurity incidents, and maintaining transparent stakeholder accountability under severe time constraints.

Case Scenario: Ransomware During Payroll Week

At 08:15 on a Monday, the organization's critical file share becomes unavailable. The incident team suspects ransomware, but the scope and entry point are not confirmed. Payroll processing is scheduled for Friday. An unverified screenshot appears in a staff group chat and is spreading outside the organization.

Known Facts

- Several teams cannot access shared files.
- Payroll processing may be delayed if access is not restored.
- The security team is preserving evidence and investigating.
- Employees, customers, leadership, legal advisers, and authorities may need different information.

Unknown Facts

Do not assume the attacker, root cause, number of affected systems, data exposure, recovery time, or regulatory reporting requirement. State what must be verified before it is communicated.

Assumptions (labelled)

ID	Assumption
A1	The organisation is fictional. All times are local time. Names are role titles: Incident Commander (IC), Security Lead, Legal and Compliance Lead, People Lead, Account Lead, Payroll and Finance Lead, Spokesperson.
A2	Out-of-band tools were set up before the incident: an SMS roster, an encrypted messaging group, a third-party hosted status page and an offline contact directory. This is unverified and must be checked at 08:30.
A3	Corporate email and staff chat are treated as untrusted until Security confirms otherwise, because the scope of the compromise is unknown.
A4	Payroll depends on the affected file share in some way that is not yet confirmed. Payroll is treated as at risk, not as failed.
A5	The employer uses an external bank or clearing partner for Friday's payroll. Its cut-off times are not known to me.
A6	Legal counsel can be reached by a verified phone number outside the corporate network.

Source of Truth: Four-Quadrant Ledger at 08:30

One time-stamped ledger is kept by the Communications Lead and approved by the Incident Commander. Working notes stay separate from cleared messages.

Quadrant	Entry	Owner	Verify by
Confirmed	The critical file share has been unavailable since 08:15.	IT lead	Confirmed
Confirmed	Several teams cannot access shared files.	Helpdesk	Confirmed
Confirmed	The security team is preserving evidence and investigating.	Security Lead	Confirmed
Confirmed	An unverified screenshot is in a staff group chat and spreading outside the organisation.	Communications Lead	Confirmed (existence only, not content)
Confirmed	Payroll processing is scheduled for Friday.	Payroll and Finance Lead	Confirmed
Unknown	The attacker, the root cause and entry point.	Security Lead	Not before forensics conclude
Unknown	The number of affected systems.	Security Lead	First read-out 10:00
Unknown	Whether any data was exposed.	Security Lead and Legal	First read-out 12:00
Unknown	The recovery time.	IT lead	No estimate until forensics support one
Unknown	Whether a regulatory reporting duty applies.	Legal and Compliance Lead	Checkpoint 12:00
Unknown	Whether the screenshot is authentic and what it shows.	Security Lead	09:00
Assumed	The incident may be ransomware. This is suspected only.	IC	Reviewed at each update
Assumed	Email and chat are unreliable. Payroll is at risk but not failed.	IC	Reviewed at each update
Next to verify	Payroll dependency on the file share and bank cut-off times.	Payroll and Finance Lead with IT lead	10:30

My Task: Build The Communication Response

As communications lead to the incident commander, build an accurate, timely, audience-specific response that remains resilient if normal collaboration systems fail.

PART 1: THE STAKEHOLDER MAP

Map how operational distress spreads across connected ecosystems. Identify at least five stakeholder cohorts and their distinct needs:

- Direct Workforce: operational guidance and reassurance on payroll stability, without unfounded speculation.
- Executive Leadership & Board: fiduciary exposure metrics, legal liabilities, strategic decision triggers.
- Key Customers & B2B Clients: service- continuity assurances and third-party risk disclosures.
- Regulatory Bodies & Legal Counsel: precise, privilege-protected, auditable documentation.
- Banking & Payroll Clearing Partners: cut-off milestones and technical data transaction boundaries.

PART 2: FIRST COMMUNICATION CYCLE

Plan the first wave in the initial four-hour operational window (08:30 to 12:30). Establish credibility, stop information leakage, and define the first three communications, their audiences, purposes, and order, including an internal message and an external or leadership-facing message.

1. Incident Command Alignment: establishes a single source of truth, verifies internal spokespersons, and imposes disclosure hygiene.
2. Internal Workforce Holding Statement: issue immediate operational rules, address the leaked screenshot, provide fallback channels.
3. Strategic Leadership & Partner Briefing: set decision thresholds, clarify containment risks, confirm the next review cadence.

My Response

Deliverable 1: One-Page Incident Communication Plan

Objective: Protect people and services, keep one verified picture, give clear next actions, and keep credibility by never speaking ahead of verified facts.

Crisis level: Declared at 08:30 because three high signals are present (see section 7).

S/N	Time	Communication and audience	Purpose	Owner and channel
1	08:30 to 08:50	Incident command alignment. IC, Security Lead, Legal and Compliance Lead, People Lead, Payroll and Finance Lead, Account Lead, Executive sponsor.	One source of truth (the ledger), named spokespeople, disclosure hygiene, approval route, crisis level confirmed.	IC. Encrypted messaging group and phone bridge.
2	Cleared by 09:10, sent 09:15	Employee holding statement. All staff, through the SMS roster.	Stop leakage, address the screenshot, give rules, state the payroll position without a promise, set the next update time.	People Lead, drafted by the Communications Lead. SMS, then manager phone tree. Cleared by Legal and Security Lead.
3	10:00	Executive briefing. CEO, executives, board chair.	Facts, unknowns, risks, decisions required, decision thresholds, update cadence.	IC. Phone and encrypted messaging.
4	11:00	Employee update 2 (SMS) and call to payroll bank or clearing partner.	Status, payroll checkpoint, confirm cut-off milestones.	People Lead and Payroll and Finance Lead.
5	11:30	Customer and partner update.	Service-impact check, support line, next update time.	Account Lead. Third-party status page and calls to key accounts. Cleared by Legal and IC.
6	12:30	Executive checkpoint and review of the first window.	Decisions, new facts, plan for the next four hours.	IC.

Update cadence. Employees: 09:15, 11:00, then every 2 hours (13:00, 15:00, 17:00), then daily at 09:00. Executives: 10:00, 12:30, then every 2 hours. Customers and partners: 11:30, 15:00, then daily at 09:00 or sooner if facts change. Bank partner: 11:00 and daily until payroll is secure. Legal and regulatory checkpoint: 12:00 and after any change to the data-exposure entry.

Payroll checkpoints: Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday at 12:00, when the Payroll and Finance Lead reports to the IC and employees are told by SMS the same day.

Disclosure hygiene. Only ledger entries cleared by the IC leave the response team. Spokespeople: People Lead (employees), Account Lead (customers), Legal and Compliance Lead (regulators and counsel), Spokesperson (media). Everyone else refers questions to them.

Not to be claimed until verified: the attacker, that it is ransomware, the root cause, the number of systems, data exposure or lack of it, a recovery time, the payroll outcome, any regulatory duty, and the screenshot's authenticity.

Deliverable 2: Stakeholder Map

Priority	Group	What they need	What we need from them (requested action)	Owner	Channel (primary / fallback)	Update cadence
1	Employees (all staff, managers, payroll team)	Safety guidance, work instructions, rumour control, honest payroll position.	Follow the rules, do not share the screenshot, report suspicious contact, use only SMS and manager calls.	People Lead	SMS roster / manager phone tree	09:15, 11:00, then every 2 hours
1	Executive leadership and board	Exposure facts, legal liabilities, options, decision triggers.	Decisions by 10:30: out-of-band channels, outside support and counsel, update approval, payroll contingency.	Incident Commander	Phone and encrypted messaging / offline-directory numbers	10:00, 12:30, then every 2 hours
2	Banking and payroll clearing partners	Cut-off milestones and technical transaction boundaries.	Confirm cut-off times and contingency options in writing.	Payroll and Finance Lead	Relationship manager phone with call-back / bank emergency line	11:00, then daily
2	Regulators and legal counsel	Precise, auditable, privilege-protected facts.	Clear legal direction on reporting duties and wording.	Legal and Compliance Lead	Counsel phone and secure channel / regulator portal	Checkpoint 12:00, then at each change

Priority	Group	What they need	What we need from them (requested action)	Owner	Channel (primary / fallback)	Update cadence
3	Key customers and B2B clients	Service impact, secure workarounds, third-party risk information that is verified, next update time.	Send urgent matters to the support line and treat unexpected messages with caution.	Account Lead	Third-party status page and account calls / support line	11:30, 15:00, then daily
3	Media and public	A verified statement if they ask.	No speculation. Enquiries go to the Spokesperson.	Spokesperson	Reactive statement on the status page / support line	Only when approved

Deliverable 3: Employee Holding Statement

Subject: Important update: IT disruption (next update 11:00)

Dear Colleagues,

Since 08:15 today, many of us cannot open shared files. Our security team is investigating a suspected cyber security incident, protecting evidence and working to restore access. We have not confirmed the cause or how many systems are affected, and we will not guess.

A screenshot is circulating in staff chat and outside the organisation. We have not verified it and it should not be treated as accurate. Please do not forward, post or comment on it. Report it, and any contact about it, to the security hotline +234 90 30000000

What to do now:

1. Do not open, move or delete files on the shared drive, and do not try to work around the outage.
2. Treat unexpected messages or links as suspicious, even from colleagues.
3. Take instructions only from SMS and your manager's phone call, not staff chat or email.
4. Send media and customer questions to Communications.

Payroll: The payroll team is assessing the effect on Friday's processing. We cannot confirm the outcome yet and will not make promises we cannot keep. You will get a payroll update at every checkpoint.

Next update: 11:00 today by SMS. Reply RECEIVED to confirm.

Warm Regards,

Chioma Onyekelu,

Incident Communications Lead.

Deliverable 4: Customer and Partner Update

Subject: Service update: IT disruption under investigation

Dear Viva Group,

At 08:15 today we identified an IT disruption affecting some internal systems. We have activated our incident response process, specialists are investigating, and containment is under way.

What we know: access to some internal shared files is unavailable.

What we do not yet know: the cause, the full extent, whether any data is affected, and when full access will return. We will not speculate, and we will tell you promptly of any finding that affects you.

What you should do: contact +234 90 30000000 for urgent matters, and treat unexpected messages claiming to be from us with caution, especially any asking for payments, passwords or file downloads.

We are checking the effect on the services you use and will confirm the position by 15:00 today.

Sincerely,

Kambilinachukwu Angela Amadi

Account Lead

Deliverable 5: Executive briefing (10:00am)

Item	Briefing
Current facts (confirmed)	The critical file share has been unavailable since 08:15 and several teams are affected. The security team is preserving evidence and investigating. An unverified screenshot is circulating in staff chat and outside the organisation. Employees received operating rules by SMS at 09:15. Payroll is scheduled for Friday and its dependency is being assessed.
Unknowns	Attacker, root cause, number of affected systems, data exposure, recovery time, regulatory reporting duty, authenticity of the screenshot, and whether payroll systems or data are affected.

Item	Briefing
Risks	(1) Payroll delay harms staff and trust. (2) Possible data exposure with legal and contractual liability. (3) Rumor and misinformation spreading from the screenshot. (4) Unreliable email and chat. (5) A premature statement that later proves wrong.
Decisions required by 10:30	(1) Approve SMS and encrypted messaging as primary channels until the network is cleared. (2) Authorise outside forensics and incident response support and outside legal counsel. (3) Approve the customer and partner update for 11:30. (4) Authorise bank pre-contact and payroll contingency planning, with no promises to staff. (5) Confirm that nobody contacts the attacker and that no ransom discussion takes place without board and legal approval.
Next update	12:30 today by phone and encrypted message, then every 2 hours.

Deliverable 6: Channel-Resilience Plan

Audience	Primary channel	Fallback channel	Owner	Confirmation method	Independence from corporate network
Response team	Encrypted messaging group and phone bridge	Direct phone calls from the offline directory, meeting in the command room	Incident Commander	Each lead replies ACK by voice within 10 minutes	Personal numbers and an external messaging service
Employees	SMS roster from an external provider	Manager phone tree, notice at the entrance	People Lead	Reply RECEIVED by SMS. Managers confirm team coverage by 10:00. Unreached staff are called.	External SMS provider, no use of corporate directory at send time

Audience	Primary channel	Fallback channel	Owner	Confirmation method	Independence from corporate network
Executives and board	Direct phone call and encrypted message	Calls to numbers in the printed directory	Incident Commander	Verbal acknowledgement and a written "Decision noted" reply	Offline directory
Customers and B2B clients	Third-party hosted status page and account calls	Support line and holding statement	Account Lead	Key accounts confirm by call or reply. The page is checked from an outside network.	Status page hosted outside corporate systems
Regulators and counsel	Counsel by phone and secure channel	Regulator portal or counsel's own email	Legal and Compliance Lead	Counsel's written acknowledgement with a time stamp	Counsel's own systems
Banking and payroll partners	Relationship manager phone call	Bank emergency line	Payroll and Finance Lead	Written confirmation from the bank's verified address, and a call-back to a number already on file	Bank's own channels

Failure Rule. An unconfirmed critical message is a failed message. If no confirmation arrives within 20 minutes, the owner uses the fallback channel and tells the IC.

Deliverable 7: Rationale for Escalation Threshold

Escalation threshold:

I used the threshold table from the course slides. Any single high signal escalates the incident to the crisis lead. At 08:30 three signals were high. The core file share was down with no restoration time, the screenshot was already outside the organisation, and Friday's payroll was at risk. I therefore escalated at once instead of waiting for the one-hour mark. Escalation moves decisions from the technical team to the Incident Commander and executives. I would lower the level only when access is restored and verified, payroll is secured, and two consecutive updates show no new external attention. Two further triggers apply: evidence that personal data was accessed or copied goes to Legal immediately, and an unresolved payroll dependency at 12:00 on Wednesday goes to the executive sponsor for contingency decisions.

What I deliberately did not claim:

I did not name the attacker, confirm ransomware, state a root cause, give the number of systems affected, or promise a recovery time. I did not say data was safe, because early claims of no data loss are often disproved. I did not say Friday's payroll will run, or that it will fail. I did not say whether a regulator must be told, because Legal must decide that after the facts are checked. I did not confirm or deny the screenshot, since either response treats an unverified claim as evidence. I also did not say containment is complete. A later correction would cost more trust than an honest admission of uncertainty.

Escalation thresholds applied

Signal	Low	Medium	High	Status at 08:30
Affected service	One team, workaround available	Several departments degraded	Core service or payroll down	High: core file share down and payroll at risk
Duration	Under 1 hour	1 to 4 hours	Over 4 hours or no estimate	High: no estimate of restoration
External exposure	No customer impact	Customers may notice	Public, media or regulator attention	High: screenshot spreading outside

Critical Reflection

The central tension was speed against accuracy. Silence would let rumours fill the gap, but a wrong statement is harder to withdraw than a short delay. The hardest dilemma was payroll. Employees were anxious, and the easiest comfort was to say that Friday's pay is safe. I could not say that, because the scope and recovery time are unknown, and a broken promise carries legal, contractual and ethical consequences, especially for staff who depend on their pay.

I balanced this by acting early and being specific about what I could control. The holding statement acknowledges the disruption, says what is unconfirmed, gives clear instructions, addresses the screenshot without confirming it, explains that payroll is being assessed, and commits to a time for the next update. I also set payroll checkpoints so that bad news would reach employees early. Honest uncertainty with a firm next time gave reassurance without a promise.

REFERENCES

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